outstrip the fastest Persian horse – indeed, it could lift both horse and rider in its trunk and '[fling] them into the air'.

The Mughal horses, as new to Hindustan as their masters, 'had never seen such terrific forms', and would run amok at their approach. No wonder that 'perturbation found its way into the hearts' of the Mughal men.[32] Still, Abdullah the Uzbek was amongst them, as also Ali Quli Shaibani, and several others who rallied the troops. On the other side, Hemu, bare-headed, shouting war cries, 'went forth with scowling brow'[33] on his elephant, Hawai – airborne. His attack was swift and strong, and threw both left and right wings of the Mughal army 'into great confusion'.[34] Central Asian horsemanship was not to be taken lightly, however. Instead of charging at the elephants, head first, they rode into Hemu's ranks diagonally, slashing with their swords, aiming to unseat enemy soldiers and trample them under 'the dagger-hooves of swift, fiery horses'.[35]

'Like thunder in April and lions in the thicket', writes Abul Fazl, the two armies 'roared and charged each other'.[36] A painting of the scene shows a man who has lost his helmet, trying to keep his long, loose hair out of his eyes with one hand and control his horse with the other; his shield flies behind him like an umbrella in a storm. Another man is caught and twisted out of shape in an elephant's trunk. A white horse's neck is splattered with blood.

'You'd say the air was all crimsoned daggers / Their steel had all become solid rubies.'[37]

Ali Quli Shaibani, in command of the centre, was holding strong, thanks to a large ditch between his men and Hemu's elephants. His archers fired volley after volley of arrows at the enemy, but nothing, it seems, would make the battle turn their way.

Some 15 kilometres away, Bairam Khan was preparing the reserves, riding through the ranks and delivering 'promises of favour and anger'.[38] It was do or die; there would be no second chances.

Did Akbar know, did he realize that Panipat was his family's second chance?[39] He wasn't a diligent student, and there is nothing to suggest that he had, as yet, acquired any interest in history, or even his own ancestry. On the other hand, it's hardly possible that Babur's great victory of 1526 on this very battlefield wasn't a familiar story to his grandson. He must have